Express JS

Express.js is a free, open-source, minimalist **backend web application framework for Node.js** used to build web servers, web applications, and APIs. Often considered the de facto standard server framework for Node.js, it streamlines the process of writing server-side logic by abstracting the complex, low-level HTTP code required by native Node.js.

Key Characteristics

1. **Fast and Lightweight:** It provides a very thin layer of essential features without obscuring the core features of Node.js.
2. It does not force a specific folder structure, database choice, or architectural pattern, giving you maximum design flexibility.
3. **Part of Popular Stacks:** It serves as the standard backend layer for JavaScript-focused stacks like **MERN** (MongoDB, Express, React, Node) and **MEAN** (MongoDB, Express, Angular, Node).

Core Features

- Easily maps incoming HTTP requests (like `GET`, `POST`, `PUT`, `DELETE`) to specific URLs and server functions.
- **Middleware:** Functions that sit in the middle of the request-response cycle. They can log data, check user authentication, parse JSON payloads, and catch errors before a response is sent.
- **Database Integration:** Connects smoothly with SQL or NoSQL databases like MongoDB, MySQL, and PostgreSQL.
- **Template Engines:** Supports HTML-rendering templates like EJS, Pug, and Handlebars to display dynamic web pages.